

Week 1: Introduction to the Qur'an

JSS1 Islamic Religious Studies (IRS) — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Islamic Religious Studies begins with the most central source of guidance in Islam — the Qur'an. This week introduces its meaning, importance, how it was revealed and preserved, and how it differs from the Hadith.

Meaning and Importance of the Qur'an

The word **Qur'an** means “the Recitation.” Muslims believe the Qur'an is the literal word of Allah, revealed to Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) through the Angel Jibril (Gabriel). It is the primary source of guidance in Islam, covering belief, worship, morality, law, and history, and is regarded as a mercy and guide for all of humankind.

Revelation of the Qur'an

The Qur'an was not revealed all at once. It came down gradually over about 23 years, beginning in the year 610 CE when Prophet Muhammad received the first revelation while in the Cave of Hira, near Makkah. This gradual process of revelation is known as **Wahy**.

Preservation of the Qur'an

The Qur'an was preserved in two main ways during and after the Prophet's lifetime:

1. **Memorization** – Many of the Prophet's companions memorized the entire Qur'an by heart; such memorizers are called **Huffaz** (singular: Hafiz).
2. **Writing** – Scribes wrote down the revelations as they were received. The full written text was later compiled into a single volume (called the **Mushaf**) during the era of the early caliphs, ensuring the Qur'an we have today matches what was revealed.

Difference between the Qur'an and Hadith

Qur'an	Hadith
The literal, direct word of Allah, revealed to Prophet Muhammad	The sayings, actions, and approvals of Prophet Muhammad, recorded by his companions
Revealed through the Angel Jibril over about 23 years	Collected and compiled by scholars after the Prophet's lifetime
The primary and highest source of Islamic guidance	The second source, used to explain and complement the Qur'an
Recited word-for-word in the exact Arabic revealed	Reported in the words of the narrator, describing what the Prophet said or did

Real-Life Application

Muslims recite portions of the Qur'an during each of the five daily prayers and turn to it for guidance in everyday decisions — from matters of worship to personal conduct and relationships with others.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Wahy	Divine revelation sent by Allah to a prophet
Mushaf	The complete written text of the Qur'an, compiled into a single volume
Hafiz (pl. Huffaz)	A person who has memorized the entire Qur'an

Evaluation Questions

- 1 What does the word "Qur'an" mean?
- 2 Through which angel was the Qur'an revealed to Prophet Muhammad?
- 3 Where did Prophet Muhammad receive the first revelation?
- 4 Over how many years was the Qur'an revealed?
- 5 Explain the two main ways the Qur'an was preserved.
- 6 What is a "Hafiz"?
- 7 What is the "Mushaf"?
- 8 State two differences between the Qur'an and the Hadith.
- 9 Why is the Qur'an considered the primary source of guidance in Islam?
- 10 In your own words, explain why memorization was so important for preserving the Qur'an.